Looking at narratives

Tzvetan Todorov devised a way of analysing narratives according to the way they move forward through different stages. He suggested that many narratives, regardless of their genre, could be broken into specific stages for analysis.

Todorov's Narrative Stages

Equilibrium – the setting is established, key character(s) are introduced and the storyline is set up.

Disruption – oppositional character(s) appear and the story takes a particular direction.

Recognition of disruption – the lives of characters and events are interwoven. Tension builds throughout this section, which is often the longest.

Attempt to repair disruption – the highest point of tension after which there is a change in dynamic.

Reinstatement of equilibrium – matters are sorted out, problems are solved and questions answered.

Emily was sick of waiting around for a wimpy prince to come and ask for her hand in marriage, so she decided to find one for herself. She soon came upon a dragon who was singeing the top of a freckle-faced boy's head.

Being a resourceful princess, Emily set a trap for the dragon and then tricked him into following her.

'You're just a silly girl, and even though it's hardly worth it, I'm going to toast you to a crisp and have you for pudding!' boomed the dragon. Just then, the branches he was standing on gave way, and he fell down a very deep well, his fire put out once and for all.

Emily returned to the boy. 'What's your name?' she asked.

'Prince Matthew,' said the boy.

'That'll do nicely,' said Emily. 'Where do you live?'

'In Happy-Ever-After,' he replied.

'That'll do nicely too,' said Emily. And with that, she and Matthew rode off together to Happy-Ever-After.



5 Emily and the dragon

Why, you may well be asking, is the children's fairy story in **5** in a book on GCSE Media Studies? The answer is that the **narrative structure** suggested by Todorov fits this story so perfectly, and there are many useful activities arising from it.

ACTIVITY 11

1 Create your own chart to show how the theory can be applied to Emily's story. The first two sections have been done to help you.

Equilibrium:	*We meet key character Emily, find out that she wants to find a prince for herself.*
Disruption:	*Emily meets oppositional characters: the dragon and boy.*
Recognition of disruption:	
Attempt to repair:	
Reinstatement:	

2 Work in a small group to find each of the stages in two films you know well.

3 Watch a short narrative – a cartoon would be a good text to use. Analyse its narrative structure by breaking it down into its five stages.

4 Think of your own simple story featuring a small boy or girl. Write a 50-word story that follows this narrative structure and read it to a partner.

Playing with narratives

Obviously not all narratives fit into the linear progression suggested by Todorov, especially if they are trying to do something different or unpredictable. For example, in the film *Back To The Future* (1985) directed by Steven Spielberg, a boy travels back in time to meet the scientist who invented time travel. The stages of the narrative in this film are not in chronological order. Can you think of any other examples?

The correct term for something that does not fit a recognised theory is a **subversion.** You may recognise these subversion techniques:

- *Flashback* – where a section of the film is referred back to, e.g. *The Hulk* (2003) directed by Ang Lee.
- *Flashforward* – where a section of the film from the future is shown before it would normally have happened, e.g. *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003) directed by the Wachowski brothers.
- *Twist* – where part of the film (often the end) is unpredictable or even shocking, e.g. *The Sixth Sense* (1999) directed by M. Night Shyamalan.
- *Parallel narratives* – where the lives of characters move alongside each other for some of the film without them meeting, e.g. *Independence Day* (1996) directed by Roland Emmerich.

KEY TERMS

Narrative structure the way in which a story is organised and shaped in terms of time and events

Oppositional characters characters who will play opposite the key central character, either in a relationship, e.g. the hero/heroine, or in conflict, e.g. the hero/villain

Subversion when a technique is used which does not fit a theory or the usual way of doing something

ACTIVITY 12

Divide into groups. Look again at Emily's story in **5**. Each group should prepare to re-tell the story, using one or more subversions. Change the original version so that the narrative no longer follows the same path. The following suggestions may help you:

- Flashback – start the story from the moment when Emily is facing the dragon.
- Flashforward – begin the story with a dream sequence in which Emily faces a fire-breathing beast.
- Twist – Emily does not have to be human!
- Parallel narratives – tell Emily's story side by side with Prince Matthew's (or the dragon's) story. This could make the audience feel differently towards them.

Audience positioning



Audiences enjoy texts most when they are really involved in them. When you analyse a media text such as a film, identify the key techniques that 'sew' the audience into it. When they are genuinely hooked into the text's narrative and development, it is as if they actually have their own position in it. You can see why this is so important – someone who is really involved in a text is much less likely to switch it off or put it back on the shelf. Here are some techniques that help an audience to become involved or positioned in a film or television text.

- **Point-of-view shots** – the camera adopts the position of a character within the text. This can be an over-the-shoulder shot, looking at whatever the character is looking at, or a shot from the point of view of the character. This is particularly powerful when the character is experiencing a strong emotion – the viewer is more likely to feel their emotion when taking their point of view.
- **Reaction shots** – the camera moves to an extreme close-up of a character's face to show their reaction to something that has happened (see **6**: Eddie Murphy in *The Nutty Professor* (1996)).



6 Reading facial expression is crucial to understanding a character's reaction

Pre-production

Storyboarding your ideas

Designing and drawing the storyboard form a vital part of the pre-production phase. A storyboard is the visual part of a film set down on paper or computer screen to look like a strip of pictures from a comic. Alongside the pictures or drawings are notes which give details of any dialogue to be spoken, any music soundtrack or sound effects, camera movements like pans or tracks, movements made by actors and sometimes notes about costume, props and, if appropriate, lighting.

Why is a storyboard important?

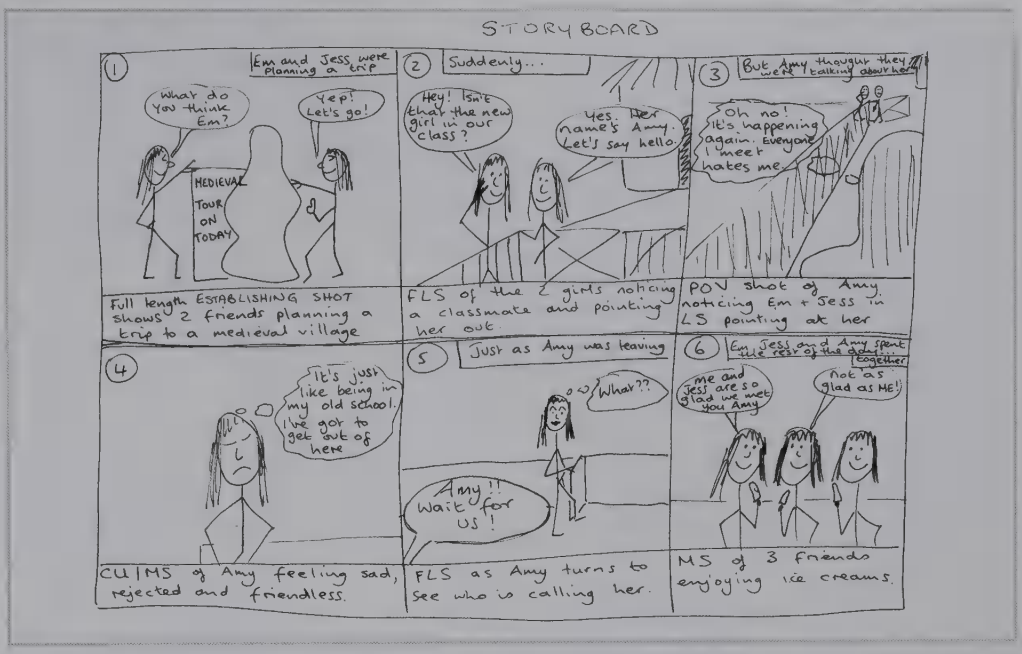
- To get visual ideas out of your head and onto paper/screen: this is often the most difficult stage of the whole filming process. Storyboarding forces you to clarify your ideas and think carefully about how to get your meaning across to the audience through pictures.
- To plan the order of the shots in a sequence: think where the camera will be placed and what movements your actors will be making.
- To save time on location: if you arrive with no idea of how the film is to be shot you will be wasting everyone's time.

Storyboarding a film

If your school has a software package such as Storyboard you can use that to storyboard your film. However, a paper version of your storyboard will do just as well. Whatever version of a storyboard you use, it should contain columns with the information shown in chart **1**.

Visuals	Shot type	Words	Music/FX	Timing
You will need to draw into this box exactly what you want the camera operator to see and film. The drawing does not need to be beautifully finished, but it must show what it is that you want to happen during the filming of this particular shot.	This is a quick back-up to your drawing in the Visuals box. It will use the common abbreviations to indicate which shot types and camera angles you wish to be used. See pages 22–24 and 39 for details of shot types.	This box will contain any words of dialogue or voice-over that accompany the shot in the visuals box.	The music is likely to run beneath a number of shots, so this column may have an arrow continuing from the boxes above showing which shots it is covering – and noting precisely which shot it begins with and at which shot it ends. The same may be true for special effects, or there may be a short noise which only occurs in this shot.	In this column show the duration of the shot or sequence.

1 How to lay out a storyboard sheet for a film



This student's completed storyboard for a photo-comic could be adapted to make a short film

Production

The production stage involves making the ideas on your storyboard into shots taken by a camera crew. You not have to shoot everything in exactly the same order as it comes on your storyboard, especially if it involves different locations. You can put things into the right order in the edit at the post-production stage.

Shot log

To save you time when you come to edit, it is a good idea always to keep a **shot log** (see the example in **3**). If you are using a sophisticated camera, you might be able to record the time code on the logging sheet, to give you an exact reference in seconds for each shot on the tape.

If, as is more likely, you are working with simpler equipment, you need to log how long the shot is and a *cumulative time*, that is, how many minutes of tape have been shot in all. This will help you find them more quickly when you come to edit. In this case it is a good idea to use a *clapper board*. All you need is a small blackboard and chalk, or a white board and marker pen. Every time you roll the camera, focus first on the clapper board on which you have written the exact shot number and take number.

TIP

If you can access *MediaStage* software, create a performance of your storyboard to refine your planning. A print out of your screen shots could be used as evidence.

KEY TERM

Shot log a list of all the shots you take in the order in which they occur on the source tape

Camera operator: JG
Camera: Canon XM 1

Location: Lydford
Date: 4th June 04

Shot no.	Set up: ELS/LS/MLS/MS/MCU/CU/ECU	Take Good (G) or No good (NG)?	Notes on shot content	Time code
1	ELS	NG	Tripod knocked	00: 31: 14
1	ELS	G	Shot down over the valley, showing village	00: 31: 27
2	LS	G	Tilt down church spire to door	00: 31: 46

Your shot log should look like this